Toddler Inhibitory Control Is Context-Bound

Response suppression becomes more reliable across toddlerhood and preschool under particular cues and supports; failure to inhibit is not character, and delay-of-gratification destiny claims belong on the Watts card.

H-AGE-TREND; MODERATE-TASK; LOW-MARSHMALLOW-DESTINY | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: EXECUTIVE-FUNCTION, REGULATION

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Early forms of stopping or delaying a prepotent response are visible in infancy and become more reliable through toddlerhood and preschool. Garon, Bryson & Smith (2008) treat inhibition as a developing component, not a switch from impulse to control. Carlson (2005) catalogued age-sensitive tasks. Carlson, Davis & Leach (2005) showed that three-year-olds wait or choose better when the reward is represented symbolically ("Less Is More") than when it is sitting there as a concrete temptation—evidence that inhibition is partly a representation problem, not a character trait.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Age trends come from batteries and longitudinal task studies. Experimental cue, language, and symbolic-distancing manipulations show that performance moves with context. That is stronger than a trait interpretation. It is not an RCT of parenting. The Watts 2018 replication remains the identification for the original strong-predictor claim; this card does not reopen it.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Population age trends are large; individual scores fluctuate with fatigue, emotion, and familiarity. Early scores have limited precision as forecasts.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a. Language comprehension, reward value, and adult scaffolding are confounds and supports. Play-as-EF-training is a different, weaker claim (pretend-play-educational-claims.md).

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Failure to inhibit is not bad parenting, weak character, or absence of learning. Toddlers are not expected to apply a rule across emotional and unfamiliar contexts. Waiting longer is not superior character.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Make rules concrete and reduce unnecessary temptation; these are proportionate supports. Ranking children by inhibition tasks, or training marshmallow performance, does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Garon, Bryson & Smith (2008), Psychological Bulletin
- Carlson (2005), Developmental Neuropsychology
- Carlson, Davis & Leach (2005), Psychological Science